

Question 45 · Unit 3 · 8 Marks

Explain the Kirkpatrick model for evaluating training effectiveness.

Answer

Donald Kirkpatrick's model evaluates training at four sequential levels, from immediate reaction to organisational results. It is the most widely used framework in HRD.

- 1. Level 1 – Reaction:** Did participants like the programme? (satisfaction, perceived relevance, trainer quality). Measured by feedback forms.
- 2. Level 2 – Learning:** Did they acquire intended knowledge, skills or attitudes? Measured by tests, demonstrations, pre–post scores.
- 3. Level 3 – Behaviour:** Do they apply learning on the job? Measured by observation, boss ratings, 360 feedback after a lag.
- 4. Level 4 – Results:** Did the organisation benefit (quality, productivity, errors, sales, safety, customer satisfaction)?
- 5. Logic of the hierarchy:** Favourable reaction helps learning; learning is needed for behaviour; behaviour should drive results—but each step can fail even if the previous succeeded.
- 6. Importance of higher levels:** Many programmes stop at smile sheets; HRD effectiveness requires behaviour and results.
- 7. Design implication:** Evaluation criteria should be set during TNA and design, not after delivery.
- 8. Limitations:** Causality at level 4 is hard; not all outcomes are numeric. Still, the model forces a complete view of effectiveness.

Conclusion. *The Kirkpatrick model thus provides a simple, comprehensive ladder for judging whether training merely pleased people or actually improved work and organisational outcomes.*